

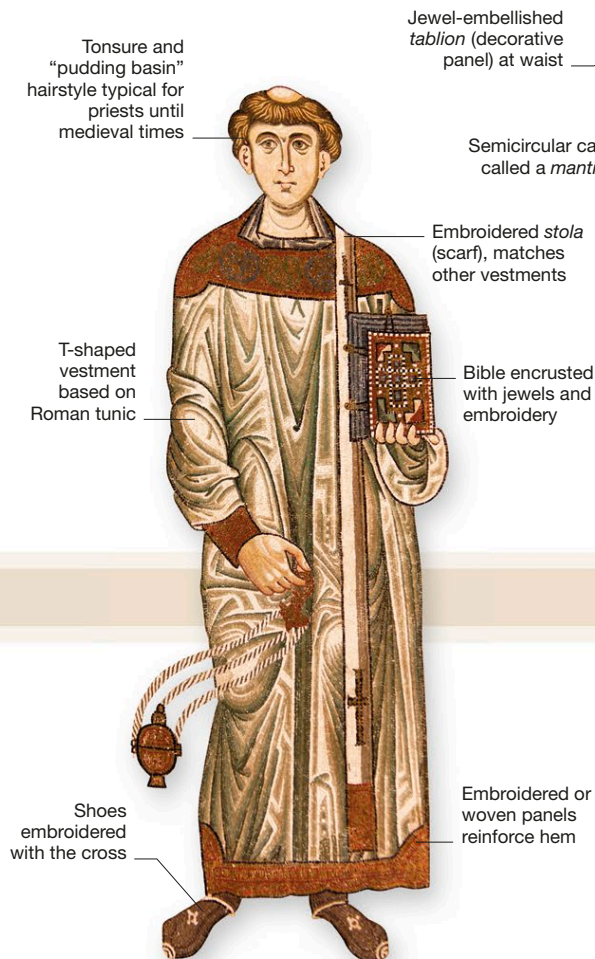
476–600CE

BYZANTINE STYLE

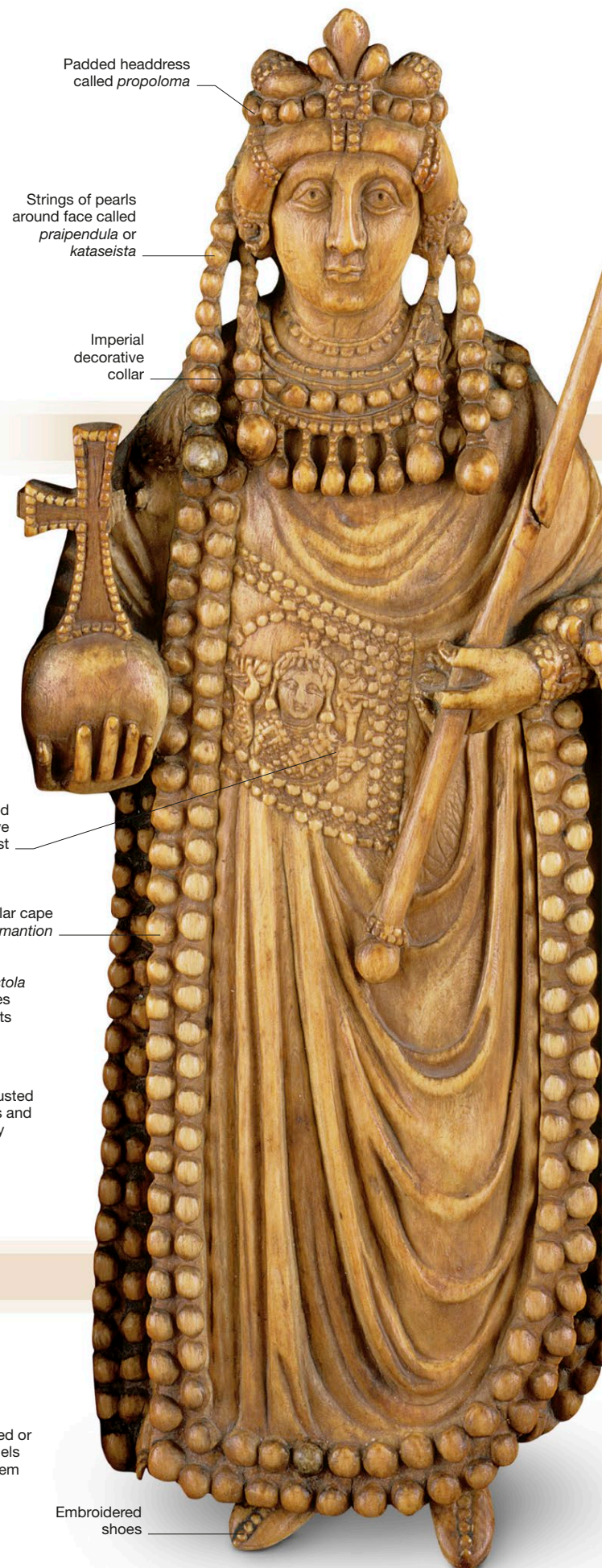
After the fall of Rome in 476CE, Constantinople (present-day Istanbul) became the centre of the Byzantine world. With the rise of the empire came opulence and a fusion of Greek, Roman, Middle Eastern, and Oriental styles. Clothes indicated social status. The richest and grandest figures, exemplified by the Emperor Justinian I and his consort Theodora, had their long, flowing gowns of richly patterned silks encrusted with jewels and gold thread. The veils and silks worn by women, and the T-shaped tunics and cloaks worn by men, were developed from Roman official dress. Some of the garments, notably the *pallium* (cloak), chasuble (outer garment), and *dalmatikon* (wide-sleeved tunic), were formalized into vestments of the Orthodox and Catholic churches. Poor working people wore plain woollen tunics, knee-length for men, with leggings, boots, and a long cloak on top.

EMPRESS THEODORA

"May I never be without the purple I wear, nor live to see the day when men do not call me 'Your Majesty'," proclaimed Theodora in 532CE, in defiance of the revolt against her husband Justinian's rule. The empress's lavish dress emphasized her wealth and status. Gold thread decorated her garments, which were coloured with expensive Tyrian purple dye and embroidered with jewels. Her fashion influence has travelled down through the centuries – designer Karl Lagerfeld drew on Theodora's embellished style for his Paris–Byzance Spring 2011 collection for Chanel.



Holy man This mosaic of St Stephen from Monreale Cathedral, Palermo, Sicily, shows him wearing bands of heavy embroidery, his vestments following the style of Roman tunics. He also wears a *stola* over his left shoulder.



Byzantine empress The Empress Ariadne in this 6th-century CE carving wears a loose-fitting robe based on the Roman toga. She carries an orb and sceptre as symbols of her imperial power over the state and the Orthodox Church.